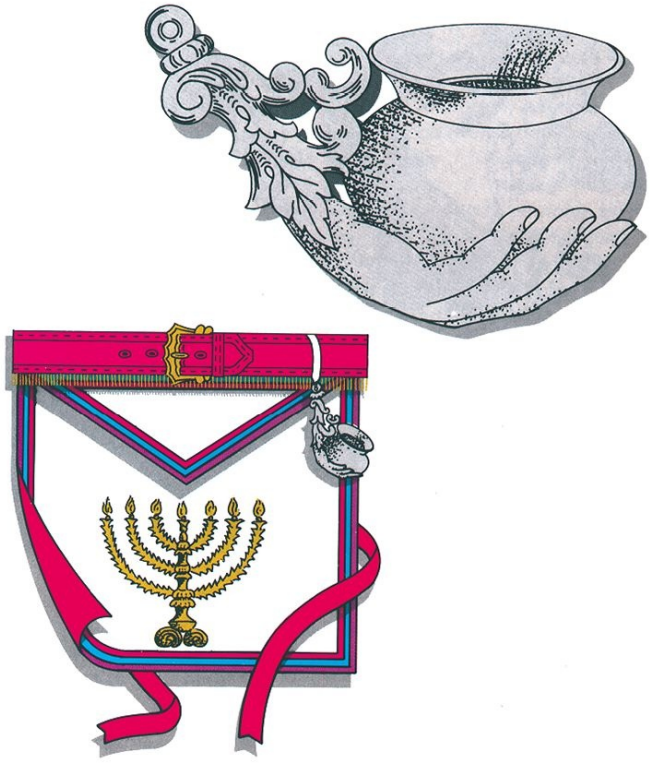
The 23rd Degree – Chief of the Tabernacle



The apron is white, lined with scarlet and bordered with red, blue and purple ribbons. In the middle is painted or embroidered the golden candelabrum with seven lights. Josephus, the great Jewish historian, is the source of the design of the apron. He defines the symbolism of the colors as follows: white, the earth, from which the flax used in fine linen is grown; red, fire, from its color; blue, the sky, for the same reason; and, purple, the sea, for it derives from a sea mollusk. But to us there are deeper meanings: white, the infinite beneficence of God; blue, His profound and perfect wisdom; red, His glory; and, purple, His power. The candelabrum symbolizes to us, as to the ancients, the seven planets: the sun, the moon, Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter and Saturn. It also represents the seven archangels and seven of the ten manifestations of Deity; specifically, the seven Sephiroth which follow Will, Wisdom and Understanding: Justice, Mercy, Beauty, Glory, Victory, Dominion and Kingdom.

A red leather belt is also worn, fringed along the lower edge with gold, from which hangs the jewel.

The jewel is a small silver censer, or ornamental cup, with a long handle; the end serves as a stand for the cup and is shaped like an open hand. It should remind us to offer up unceasingly to God the incense of good deeds and charitable actions dictated by a pure and upright heart.

DUTIES

Be devoted to the service of God.

Constantly endeavor to promote the welfare of man. Act with proper subordination to your superiors.

LESSONS

Simple faith is wiser than vain philosophy.

A society's concept of the Deity and the universe are consistent with its development.

FOR REFLECTION

What is the nature of God?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

The standards of the twelve tribes of Israel, darkness, light, the colors scarlet, white, blue and purple.

Here we begin the symbolic initiations into the Mysteries practiced by the ancients from whom Masonry has obtained her great truths. Pike tells us:

> *The instruction now conveyed by books and letters was of old conveyed by symbols; and the priest had to invent or to perpetuate a display of rites and exhibitions, which were not only more attractive to the eye than words, but often to the mind more suggestive and pregnant with meaning* (p. 354).

In the set we find testimony to this practice and the source for its design. The ritual describes in great detail the tabernacle and surrounding court of Moses

found in Chapters 26 to 36 of Exodus. The set and its symbols are elaborate to help us understand these ancient teachings.

CEREMONY

Lodges of Chiefs of the Tabernacle are styled Courts and represent an encampment of the twelve tribes of Israel in the wilderness. The tribes are identified by twelve standards located around the room in specific order near the walls, each bearing the name of the tribe and the symbol associated with it. We also encountered the Twelve Tribes in the 19th Degree. The four cardinal directions are emphasized in the description:

LOCATION	TRIBE	SYMBOL
Northeast	Issachar	Ass
East	**Judah**	**Lion**
Southeast	Zebulon	Ship
South-Southeast	Simeon	Sword
South	**Ruben**	**Man**
Southwest	Gad	Stars
West-Southwest	Manasseh	Vine
West	**Ephraim**	**Bull**
Northwest	Benjamin	Wolf
North-Northwest	Asher	Tree
North	**Dan**	**Eagle**
North-Northeast	Naphtali	Deer

The cardinal directions are represented by the lion, the bull, the man and the eagle. Parts of each form the body of the Sphinx, an ancient symbol of the concept of an enigma, a riddle or puzzle. Here they represent the Mysteries. For now, we should be content to understand that the Mysteries treated of God, Man and Nature (p. 357); and thus, the standards are a symbol of the universe, for we find the stars, man, plant and animal life, the sea (ship) and the technology of man (sword) represented.

In the center of the lodge is a representation of the Tabernacle of Moses, a rectangular tent, with two sets of curtains of white, blue, scarlet and purple thread woven together. We do not see the separate colors unless by close scrutiny. Hence, the curtains are themselves a symbol of the veiling of symbols by the ancients and in Masonry. These curtains should be embroidered with cherubim or animals with the bodies of lions, the feet of bulls, the faces of men

and the wings of eagles. They allude to the four cardinal directions and the symbols on the standards of the four principle tribes of Israel as well as the sources of those symbols, the Book of Ezekiel (1:10) and the Revelation to St. John (4:7).

The furnishings include the Altar of Sacrifice, a bronze basin filled with water, the Table of Presence or Shew–Bread upon which are twelve loaves of bread and wine, the Altar of Incense, the Ark of the Covenant, and the gold candelabrum with seven lights (specifically, not candles). The lights represent the seven planets of the ancient world: the sun, the moon, Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter and Saturn.

The presiding officer represents Aaron, the brother of Moses, and is called the "Venerable High Priest." The Wardens represent Eleazar and Ithamar, sons of Aaron and are referred to as "Excellent Priests." Aaron was the head of the Judaic priesthood from whom all the Hebrew priests traced their descent. The Venerable High Priest wears the dress of the priests in Biblical times– a gown of white with a tunic of blue, both of which are embellished with embroidery of blue, scarlet and purple. Over these he wears the breastplate of cloth on which are twelve precious stones as described in Exodus 28:17–20 and seen in the illustration for the 19th Degree.

The candidate represents Eliaseph, a Levite, who comes to receive the first degree, or lowest grade, of initiation into the Mysteries of the Jewish priesthood. In the Old Testament, a sharp distinction is made between the Aaronite priests and the Levites. The Levites were given to Aaron and his sons by the Lord (Numbers 3:9). In the threefold hierarchy of the priesthood the Levites are third after the high priest and the priests, both hereditary positions. The Levites functioned as subordinate officials in charge of the lower duties of the sanctuary: assisting the priests, cleaning the sacred vessels, preparing cereal offerings, and serving the congregation. In Numbers 8:5–13 we find the Levites were installed by a ceremony consisting of lustration (purifying by water), shaving the body, sacrifice, the laying on of hands and solemn presentation to God.

The legend is based on the Old Testament story of Korah, Dathan and Abairam. According to one version Korah was a Levite priest and in the other was not; it doesn't matter which version is chosen. Korah led a rebellion against Moses protesting that since all the congregation are holy and the Lord is among them (Numbers 16:3), the Aaronites should not be the only ones permitted to discharge the religious offices. Dathan and Abairam are interwoven in the story and were leaders of a revolt by laymen against the civil authority claimed by Moses. Moses invited Korah and his followers to trial by ordeal; they brought fire pans filled with incense so that the Lord could choose who would perform the religious offices.

The candidate hears of the fate of Korah, Dathan and Abairam—they were swallowed up by the earth for their presumptive actions and their followers consumed by fire; further, those who questioned this fate died of the plague. This is a simple lesson on learning proper subordination to superiors. The God of this story is vengeful and merciless.

Then a feeble light is added to the cell, dispelling some of the darkness. The candidate is instructed to pray for mercy and forgiveness—a hint of the coming light and the changing Hebrew perception of God, from vengeful and merciless to beneficent and loving. The candidate is warned to approach the Mysteries with sincerity to serve God and his fellow man and with a pure heart; that is, having repented of his sins. His purity of heart, generosity and devotion are acknowledged by actions symbolic of lustration and shaving of the body.

Having passed through the symbolic initiation and been accepted as a Chief of the Tabernacle, the symbolic meaning of the colored curtains is explained. We learn first the meaning ascribed by the Hebrews: scarlet was emblematical of fire, white of the earth, blue of the air and purple of the sea (Josephus, *Antiquities* iii.7.7). But to the Mason, white is emblematical of the beneficence of God, blue of God's profound and perfect wisdom, crimson of His glory and purple of His power.

Hints of future degrees are also presented in the final instruction. The number seven is briefly explored; we are told that it was a sacred number in many

religions. To the ancient Hebrews there were seven planets which corresponded to the seven colors of the prism and the seven notes of the musical scale. Assigned to the seven planets were the seven great archangels, the seven secondary causes which govern the world, and the seven virtues. We shall learn the symbolism of the number seven to the Mason in later degrees.

Finally, the Court of the Chiefs of the Tabernacle is closed so that we may meditate in silence and prepare for the duties of tomorrow wise counsel for those involved in philosophical speculations.

LECTURE

This lecture is an introduction to, and justification for, the Mystery Degrees: Chief of the Tabernacle, Prince of the Tabernacle, Knight of the Brazen Serpent and Prince of Mercy. The most widely disseminated of the Mysteries were those of Greece, Egypt and Persia; although Mysteries are known from other cultures in such places as India, Phoenicia, Judea and Rome. These varied Mysteries had common purposes and treated of God, man and nature:

> *Originally the Mysteries were meant to be the beginning of a new life of reason and virtue. The initiated or esoteric companions were taught the doctrine of the One Supreme God, the theory of death and eternity, the hidden mysteries of Nature, the prospect of the ultimate restoration of the soul to that state of perfection from which it had fallen, its immortality, and the states of reward and punishment after death. The uninitiated were deemed Profane, unworthy of public employment or private confidence, sometimes proscribed as Atheists, and certain of everlasting punishment beyond the grave (p. 359).*

This degree, Chief of the Tabernacle, is the Masonic equivalent of what were known as the Lesser Mysteries. Pike tells us:

> *... most of the Ancient nations ... in addition to their public worship, ... [had] a private one styled the Mysteries; to which those only were admitted who had been prepared by certain ceremonies called initiations* (p. 352).

The Lesser Mysteries were received by all, but only a few were initiated into

the Greater Mysteries.

Pike believed that the Mysteries were originally few and simple, teaching the great truths of the primitive religion and morality. Over time, this purity was lost, the rites of initiation became more complicated and more degrees were invented to maintain only a few adepts who were initiated into the higher degrees.

The method of instruction emphasized in the Mysteries utilized symbols and allegories, treating a mysterious subject mysteriously (p. 354). Masonry still follows this manner of teaching because:

> *No better means could be devised to rouse a dormant intellect, than those impressive exhibitions, which addressed it through the imagination; which, instead of condemning it to a prescribed routine of creed, invited it to seek, compare, and judge. The alteration from symbol to dogma is as fatal to beauty of expression, as that from faith to dogma is to truth and wholesomeness of thought* (p. 356).

The Ancient Mysteries:

The Powers revered in the Mysteries were all in reality Nature–Gods; none of whom could be consistently addressed as mere heroes, because their nature was confessedly super–heroic. ... [The Mysteries] *were not in any open hostility with the popular religion, but only a more solemn exhibition of its symbols; or rather a part of itself in a more impressive form. ...They offered a perpetual problem to excite curiosity, and contributed to satisfy the all pervading religious sentiment,* ... (pp. 354–355).

In symbolical forms the Mysteries exhibited THE ONE, of which THE MANIFOLD [nature] *is an infinite illustration, containing a moral lesson, calculated to guide the soul through life, and to cheer it in death* (p. 357).

The Mysteries and Masonry:

[The Grecian Mysteries established by Pythagoras] *taught the true method of obtaining a knowledge of the Divine laws, of purifying the soul from its imperfections, of searching for truth, and of practising virtue; thus imitating the*

perfections of God. ... Particularly [Pythagoras] *inculcated Silence, Temperance, Fortitude, Prudence and Justice. He taught the immortality of the soul, the Omnipotence of God, and the necessity of personal holiness to qualify a man for admission into the Society of Gods* (p. 366).